uncles for the sake of the throne.[44] The *Vamshatthapakasini*, in predicting the destiny of Ashoka, follows the forms and conventions of the chronicle on which it is a commentary. In inserting the figure of Ashoka in this cycle of prediction, with an Ajivika foretelling the future (all of which is missing in the *Mahavamsa*), it could represent the incorporation of the Ashoka legend of the Northern Buddhist tradition.

Forms and conventions apart, are there any other reasons for the 'coming' of an emperor to have been predicted in this way? And are there other kinds of events that are prophesied in this way, or other historical figures whose destinies are similarly prefigured in ancient India?

By the time Ashoka was born, prophecies and prognostications—if one goes by allusions to 'events' that either would transpire or transpired as a consequence of particular signs—had long become acceptable practice, an incorporation of superstition into the dominant belief systems by which everyday life was lived. Future events, auspicious or otherwise, could be indicated by the cries of certain kinds of birds—as the oldest Indian text, the *Rig Veda*, indicates.[45] Birds also figure as omens in another text of the same genre, the *Atharva Veda*, in which something fallen from the mouth of a black bird was considered ominous because that kind of bird was supposed to be the mouth of Nirrti, goddess of death and corruption.[46] The disturbing or disruptive behaviour of birds and animals appears in all kinds of early literature, from the *Mahabharata* where a category of ascetics depicted are those who understand the cries of birds and monkeys, to the *Parantapa Jataka* in which the Bodhisattva (the future Buddha) learns to understand the meanings of animal cries while studying at the city of Taxila.[47] In other instances the signs to be 'read' depend upon the constellation of planets. A boy, for instance, believed to have been born on an inauspicious astrological constellation might himself die or bring about the death of his father or his mother.[48]